CLAUDE CODE · GOOD PRACTICES

Long sessions, less waste

How Claude Code spends your usage limit, and ten habits that make your plan last longer without losing any work between sessions.

The one thing to know

Every message re-reads the whole conversation. While the conversation is cached, that re-reading is cheap. The cache lasts **one hour** after your last message (subagents get only five minutes). Come back later, and your first message writes the entire conversation into the cache again, at twice the normal input price.

So a big session left alone over lunch costs far more to pick up than it did to pause.

Where one heavy user's month went

44%	40%	16%	15%
Re-reading the conversation on each message	Writing the conversation into the cache	Claude's actual answers, code and thinking	Coming back to a big session after its hour ran out

One Claude Max 20x user, 30 days, 247 sessions, priced at Anthropic's API rates. More than half of all messages carried over 200K tokens of conversation.

Your work is already saved

Files are written to disk the moment Claude edits them. Closing a session, archiving it or starting a new one never undoes them. Archived sessions keep their full transcript too.

What lives only in the chat is the thinking around the work: the decisions, what was tried, what comes next. **Write that down** in a notes file, and the chat itself stops mattering.

Not sure? Ask: *"Is everything saved for the next session?"*

Starting fresh is cheap

WHAT IT COSTS	IN MESSAGES*
One message in a session over 800K	1
A fresh session catching up from notes (its first ten messages)	**about 8**
Coming back to a big session after the hour	**about 30**

After catching up, the fresh session holds about 117K instead of 800K or more, so **every message after that costs about a seventh** as much.

* Medians from the same user's logs, counted in messages of a session over 800K.

Ten habits

1. **One chapter per session**
   When the topic changes, start a new session. Small sessions are cheap on every message.

2. **Save the state before you stop**
   Where it stopped, what comes next, what waits on you. One minute of writing saves the whole pickup.

3. **Keep a tracker in every project**
   One `TRACKER.md` that every session reads first. There is an example at the bottom of this page.

4. **Give each session an ID and a marker**
   Like `#W4 Website · contact form`. Put `@` in front when it waits on you, `✓` when done, `!` when blocked.

5. **Leaving for over an hour? Wrap up first**
   Save the state while the cache is warm. Back within a few hours, mid-task? Send a short message before the hour is up. That keeps it warm for another hour, for the price of one ordinary message.

6. **Past about 400K, start fresh**
   By then every message re-reads about three novels' worth of text. Wrap up and continue in a new session from the notes.

7. **Prefer a fresh start over compacting**
   Compacting keeps a summary you didn't write and can't check. A fresh session reads notes you wrote on purpose.

8. **Archive freely**
   Archiving only files a session away. It costs nothing and the transcript stays. Reopening an old, long one is what costs.

9. **Stop retry loops**
   If the same command failed twice with nothing changed in between, a third try won't help. Change something, or ask what's in the way.

10. **Match the model to the job**
    Use the most capable model for hard thinking and design. Hand routine sweeps, bulk edits and checks to a cheaper one.

Make it automatic

Session Guardian is a free, open-source plugin for Claude Code, with the tracker and session ID rules ready to paste into `CLAUDE.md`.

- A countdown above the prompt before a big session's cache runs out, with what coming back will cost
- A nudge at 400K and 800K to wrap up and start fresh
- `/wrapup`: Claude saves the state, marks the session done and hands you a one-line prompt for the next one
- A pause on the third identical failing command

github.com/A-rdit/session-guardian

```
# Tracker (Website)

## Sessions (latest 5)
- #W7 · Checkout · tests · working
- #W6 · Homepage · new hero · ✓

## Waiting on you
- Pick a hero photo (Homepage)

## Branches
### Checkout
- Test the card payment
- ~~Move coupon field~~ (9 Oct)
```

Figures from one user's real logs. Yours will differ; the pattern holds for any long session.

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